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d) The belongings are shared out (kugadza nhaka)

The ceremony of selection is simple. After the wife (or wives) has stepped over the bow she sits down on a mat, and one of her brothers or a *muzukuru* (sister's or daughter's son) asks her: "Whom do you choose for chopping the wood?". Or: "Your husband has died, what are you thinking now?"

Basically the woman is free to choose — free within the existing kinship circle. She also has the right to marry a stranger, or to refuse further marriage. The latter is open to the first wife, for example (often because of her age). The choice made at this ceremony has usually been agreed upon beforehand by the two partners. So, as a rule, there are no big surprises.

Again, the *muzukuru* (sister's or daughter's son) acts as one of the most important masters of ceremonies in the matter of sharing out the inheritance. A man is said to love his daughters more than his sons. The Karanga to even further and say that the children of a man's daughters are closer to him than his own sons because they come from his daughter's uterus. There is a saying: "The *muzukuru* is more than one's own child (*muzukuru wakakunda mwana*)". This refers to daughter's and sister's children but not to the sons of one's own son or brother.

The saying quoted above has another meaning too, i.e. that a man is great and is honoured by many through the seeds (*mbeu*) of others, of strangers, who help him enlarge his family. Or, to look at it in yet another way: a father, together with his own children, enables an alien family to grow. He thereby acquires many *vazukuru* who honour him during his life-time and call him *sekuru* (grandfather) or *ambuya* (grandmother) and even acknowledge and honour him as an ancestral spirit. This is why, the Karanga say, a man always wants daughters. Through them he acquires the *vazukuru* who are of alien blood.

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There are various aspects to be considered in connection with the role of the *muzukuru* at the sharing out of belongings. They can be explained on the basis of his special position as sister's or daughter's son. Thus, for example, the children of a son of the deceased cannot take part in the share-out because they cannot marry the dead man's wives. But it is at the remarriage of the wives that the *muzukuru* plays an important part. On the one hand, he is the ideal person where the material belongings are concerned. As a non-consanguine he cannot  321 inherit these possessions (except the wives), but he is all the same very closely connected with this clan in which he occupies a position of trust. For example, in quarrels the *muzukuru* (daughter's but also sister's son, cf p. 175* seq) is consulted: the relatives must "cool off" in his presence or, as a common saying goes, "they must no longer be violent".

We are here interested solely in the problem of the wife's inheritance. There are always three groups, the Karanga say, who claim these women: the brothers, the sister's sons and the sons of the dead man's daughters. The brothers of the deceased have priority. However, frequently they are old and so less desirable than the young *vazukuru*.

It is only the sisters' sons who can marry these women (of joking relationship, p. 175*) – not, however, the dead man's sons or those of his brother. A son's hierarchical status is below that of his father or grandfather. Therefore, he can marry none of these women (for exceptions, cf Holleman ⁸³) for this would upset the hierarchical order, i.e. the status of the children of such marriages would be equal to that of their father. What is more, the paternal grandfather is a highly respected ancestor whereas the maternal one is comparatively low in status (thus in this lineage, a marriage is possible). In the succession of grandfather-father-son, there is consanguinity, and this requires that the hierarchical order be maintained (cf p. 156*); there is however, no consanguinity in the mother's kinship lineage. But a child's descent from the female line's uterus (daughter's and sister's son) gives precedence. This becomes clear from the expression "the *muzukuru* is more than one's own child".

So it is once again the mother – let us call her Chipo – who gives to her child (meaning here the *muzukuru*) its important position because, as the Karanga say, "she lent her uterus to the child" (cf p. 276 seq). From this angle, one can (when a widow marries a *muzukuru*) understand the expression "we give the wife (of the deceased) to our daughter or sister" (meaning Chipo).

Once, Chipo brought into the clan the cattle for her father or brother. In the clan's view this entitles her to a repayment. This right is exercised by her son (the *muzukuru*) when the women are allotted.

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83. J.F. Holleman, op. cit., 1969, p. 238.

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